Between Fragmentation and Coercion: Accommodative Power-Sharing for Iran's Ethnic Diversity

The London School of Economics and Political Science
Department of Government
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Nima Movahedi

Abstract

Iran's territorial integrity has historically depended on coercive homogenization: successive regimes suppressing ethnic diversity to prevent fragmentation. Yet, with Persians comprising only 61% of the population and nearly every major minority concentrated along international borders adjacent to ethnic kin groups, this strategy has produced deep ethnic cleavages that the current institutional design can no longer contain. This paper evaluates three accommodationist power-sharing mechanisms, centripetalism, consociationalism, and ethno-federalism, against Iran's ethnic complexity, territorial vulnerabilities, grievance landscape, and comparative evidence. As the analysis suggests that no single mechanism is sufficient, rather, a hybrid framework, with a constitutionally entrenched partial ethno-federation anchored by liberal consociational principles and centripetal electoral incentives, presents the most viable institutional path for a post-transition Iran. Generations of compounding horizontal inequalities demand an institutional response of corresponding depth; this synthesis offers one that can sustain Iran's territorial integrity by accommodating its diversity rather than suppressing it.

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I. Introduction

With one of the world's most ethnically diverse demographies, Iran's territorial integrity has largely endured where comparable civilizations have fractured. Yet the concentration of minority populations along Iran's periphery has cultivated a critical vulnerability that internal and external actors have repeatedly sought to exploit. Recent Iranian history bears witness to this threat: Russian and British imperial pressures siphoned Iranian territory to compose the South Caucasus, Afghanistan, and Bahrain, while separatist movements from within produced short-lived ethno-states (Abbas, 2013). This dynamic ingrained a deep anxiety in Iran's political consciousness, guiding successive regimes toward intensified centralization. The Safavid Dynasty institutionalized Shi'ism to construct a sectarian boundary with its Sunni neighbors; the Qajar Dynasty centralized provincial authority and restricted tribal rights; the Pahlavi Dynasty expanded the state's coercive capacity to suppress interethnic differences and consolidate Iranians under a singular national identity (Mostofi, 2026). The Islamic Republic inherited and intensified this logic further, mandating a unitary Shia Persian identity with systemic exclusion and repression of its minority populations (Farouk & Jalal, 2026). Across each era, the governing assumption has remained constant: territorial integrity requires coercive homogenization.

This model is far from sustainable. The state's strategy of suppression relied on centralized control over political, economic, and social dimensions of Iranian life; any divergence from this monopoly threatened its hold. Within Iran's multi-ethnic landscape, generations of inequality have produced deepening grievances met by increasingly harsh responses– perpetuating a cycle of ethnic division and eroding central authority. Now, as the Islamic Republic's coercive capacity has been further weakened in the aftermath of unprecedented national resistance, economic collapse, and the assassination of its most senior leaders, Iran's ethnic fractures are growing beyond what its current institutional design can contain. The risk of fragmentation is no longer theoretical.

Yet alternative proposals have been largely insufficient. Some assume that a moderated government within the existing framework can restore stability; others believe democratic elections alone will suffice. Both misdiagnose the problem: the former cannot address grievances embedded in the institutional design itself, while the latter risks replicating minority exclusion

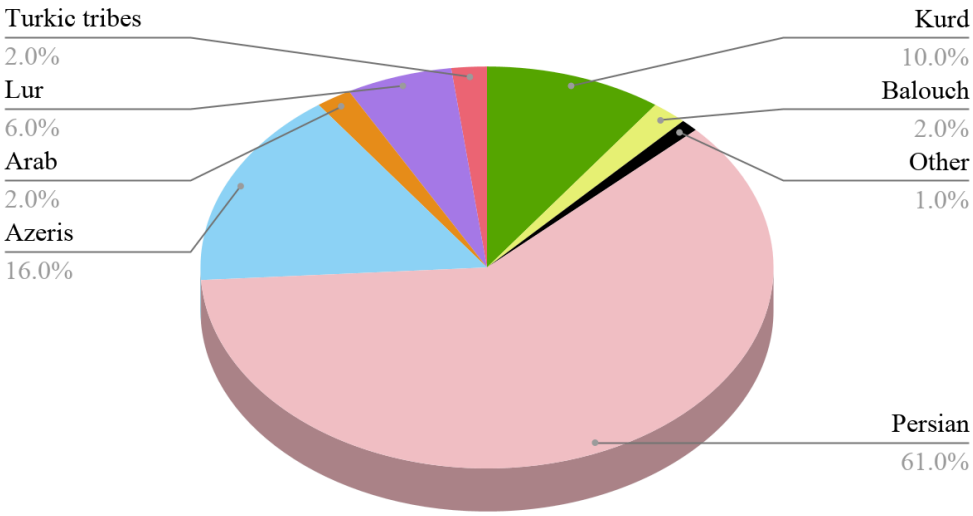
through a Persian demographic majority. What is needed is accommodative power-sharing: frameworks designed for societies divided by deep ethnic, religious, and linguistic cleavages. This paper evaluates three such models, centripetalism, consociationalism, and ethno-federalism, against Iran's unique conditions. Each is assessed against criteria derived from the theoretical literature: ethnic complexity fit, territorial integrity compatibility, grievance responsiveness, and comparative record. The paper argues that no single mechanism is independently sufficient for a post-transition Iran; rather, a combination of their key elements produces the most viable framework for balancing ethnic diversity with preserving territorial integrity.

II. Iran's Ethnic Puzzle

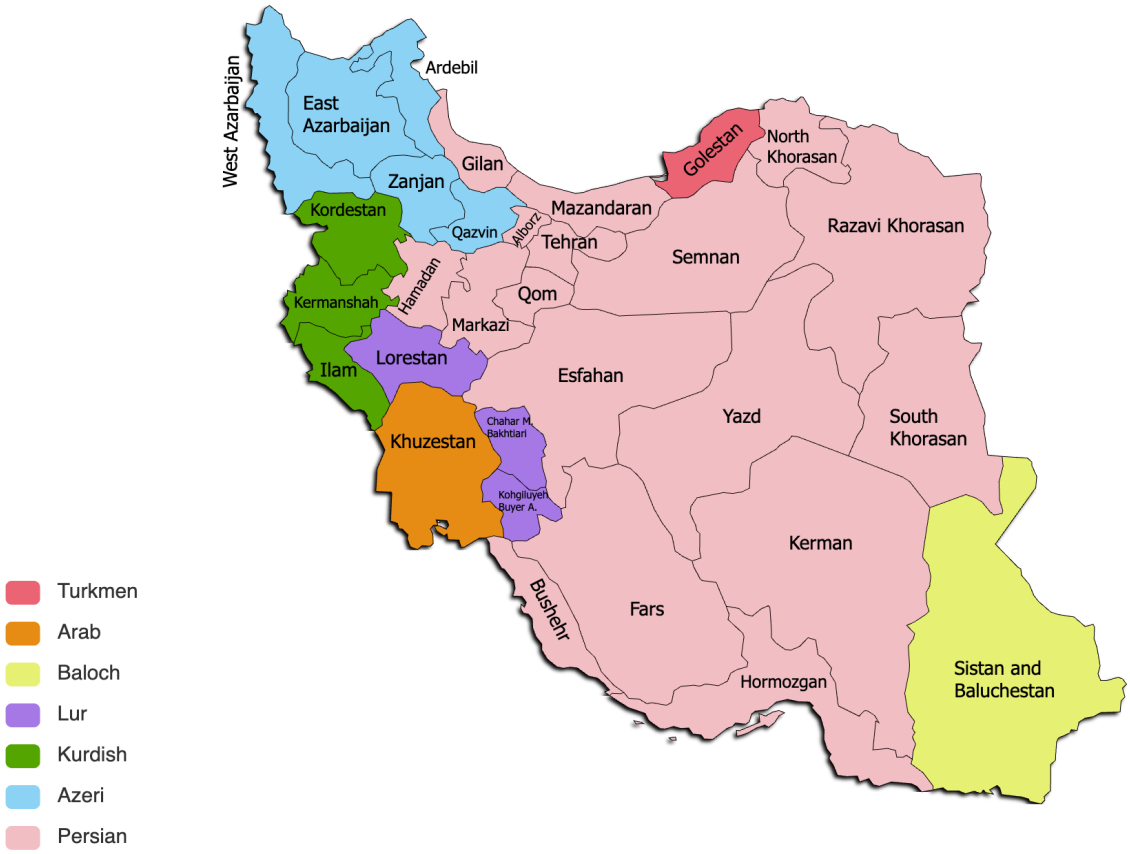
Iran is considered one of the most ethnically diverse states in the Middle East, yet its diversity is frequently misunderstood. Persians, the largest ethnic group comprising approximately 61% of the country, largely dominate Iran's cultural and political landscape despite being far from a homogenous whole. The other 39% is distributed among several significant ethnic groups: Azerbaijani Turks (16 percent), Kurds (10 percent), Lurs (6 percent), Baloch (2 percent), Arabs (2 percent), and other smaller communities of Turks, Armenians, Assyrians, and Afro-Iranians (Chughtai & Hussein, 2026). While the Islamic Republic conducts regular national censuses, they ceased mapping ethnicity; the last Iranian census to do so was the 1976 survey under the Pahlavi dynasty (Minority Rights Group, 2026). All contemporary demographic figures are therefore non-governmental estimates.

This paper concentrates on major ethno-linguistic groups whose territorial concentration along international borders poses the most direct challenge to institutional design and territorial integrity. Smaller groups such as Baha'is fall outside this scope, as their grievances, while serious, do not carry the same salience. Other communities, such as the Gilaki and Mazandarani, are not treated as distinct from Persians since demographic studies consistently subsume them due to high rates of cultural assimilation and linguistic proximity to Farsi (DaBell, 2013). These groups are not uniformly dispersed across the country and follow an observable peripheral pattern.

Iran's Demographic Population



Iran's Ethnic Distribution by Province



Ethnic Group	Region(s)	Bordering Kin State
Turkmen	Northeastern provinces	Turkmenistan
Arabs	Khuzestan (southwest)	Iraq
Baloch	Sistan and Baluchestan (southeast)	Pakistan / Afghanistan
Lur	Embedded between Persian, Kurdish, and Arab regions	None
Kurds	Western provinces	Iraqi Kurdistan
Azeri Turks	Northwestern provinces	Azerbaijan
Persians	Central provinces	None

With the exception of the Persians and Lurs, every major ethnic group is concentrated in provinces along international borders adjacent to their ethnic kin. This peripheral distribution is not coincidental but the product of centuries of migration along the Silk Road, imperial relocations (e.g., the Safavid Dynasty deported Kurds from central Iran to Khorasan), and border arbitration influenced by foreign powers (e.g., the 1907 Anglo-Russian Convention). The cumulative result is a multi-ethnic geography that sits along the state's international frontiers, providing most ethnic groups with easy access to their bordering kin.

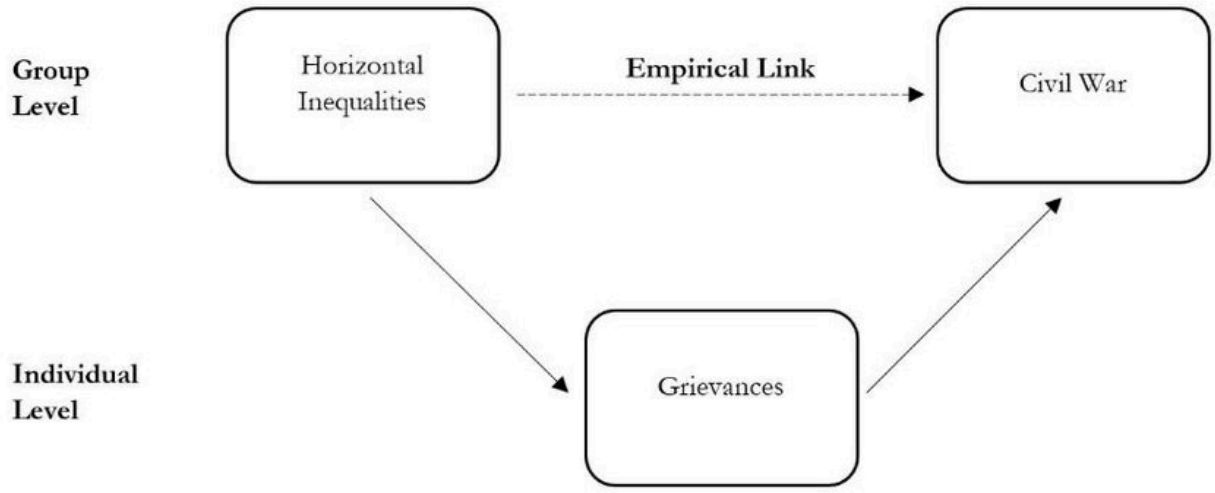
III. Grievance Structure

Ethnic diversity alone does not constitute an institutional design problem- many similarly diverse states govern without Iran's demographic vulnerability. What transforms Iran's ethnic plurality into a political crisis comes from decades of state discrimination against its minority populations. Seeking to construct a highly homogenous Shia Persian society, the Islamic Republic perceives diverging ethnic identities as subversive to its regime (Farouk & Jalal, 2026). Consequently, minority groups face consistent marginalization by the government seeking to coercively assimilate all Iranians under a single nationalist identity.

These acts have produced horizontal inequalities between a dominating Persian class and repressed minority groups, producing deep ethnic cleavages and cementing resentment against the state. Horizontal inequalities produce grievances, which, as Cederman et al. observe, make a state vulnerable to civil war and internal conflict (Cederman et al., 2013). The following analysis

examines Iran's most salient ethnic grievances across three dimensions –cultural, economic, and political– and the extent to which state injustices have made the current institutional design structurally incompatible with maintaining Iran's diverse landscape.

Cederman et al. (2013) Grievance Framework



Cultural Repression

Despite Article 15 of the Iranian Constitution explicitly allowing for "the use of regional and tribal languages…as well as for teaching of their literature in schools", the Islamic Republic has discriminated against minority languages as a means to pursue a systematic cultural homogenization (Iran Human Rights, 2013). Minority languages, such as Kurdish, Baloch, Arabic, and Turkish, are barred from use by government institutions or from being taught in the public education system (Sinaiee, 2023). Beyond marginalizing ethnic cultures in the service of promoting a Persian identity, this discriminatory policy has contributed to an educational disparity among minority students: students who are raised speaking only their mother tongue struggle to keep up in classes taught in Farsi, the language of Persians. Former educators in Khuzestan Province attributed how, within the largely Arabic-speaking region, "the government's refusal to allow the teaching and speaking of Arabic in schools has led to poor grades and an increase in dropout rates" (Iran Human Rights, 2013). Educators who have advocated for mother-tongue education have been forced into exile or arrested, as Iranian security forces frame "the education in or preservation of native languages…[as] separatism" (Iran Human Rights, 2021). The repression of cultural identity represents not merely an injustice but the product of

Iran's totalitarian and exclusionary institutional design. To overcome these grievances, a system is needed that is not vulnerable to Iran's diversity and is capable of supporting an Iran that reflects its multicultural diversity.

Economic Marginalization

The peripheral provinces inhabited by ethnic minorities are consistently among Iran's most underdeveloped regions. Khuzestan illustrates this particular economic disparity as, despite its oil fields contributing to almost a quarter of Iran's annual GDP, Khuzestan has been ranked the second-most miserable province and last in employment in Iran (Gholipour, 2021). Mohammad Ansar, a member of parliament from Khuzestan, attributes this to how "only half of those employed by these [oil] companies are local Arabs", as "racism towards Arabs has denied them opportunities to work" (DaBell, 2013). Ansar is referencing the Gozinesh Law, which prevents employment and educational opportunities in Iran for those who are not aligned with the state's ideological and religious values (U.S. Department of State, 2023). As the largest employer in Iran, the Islamic Republic "gozinesh has been used to marginalize Kurds and others and to expressly deny them employment in the state sector…[and] in parts of the private sector as well" (Amnesty International, 2008). Baloch Sunni minorities also face these effects, as the "government's unwillingness to create jobs and hire Baloch people" has contributed to a wide gap in economic prosperity between their Persian counterparts (Khan & Laoutides, 2024). Thus, minority-concentrated provinces such as Khuzestan, Kurdistan, and Sistan and Baluchestan remain underdeveloped, with consistently higher poverty rates and poorer health conditions compared to Persian-majority provinces (DaBell, 2013). This pattern of economic discrimination breeds the type of horizontal inequalities that, through decades of reinforcement, embed deep grievances against the state's institutional architecture and require new mechanisms for resolution.

Political Discrimination

Iran's response to dissent and political plurality among ethnic groups has consistently been characterized by disproportionate violence. Kurdish educators have been executed for teaching students about their political culture, Arab cultural activists in Khuzestan have been killed for "enmity against God", and Baloch political prisoners have been tortured and executed on state

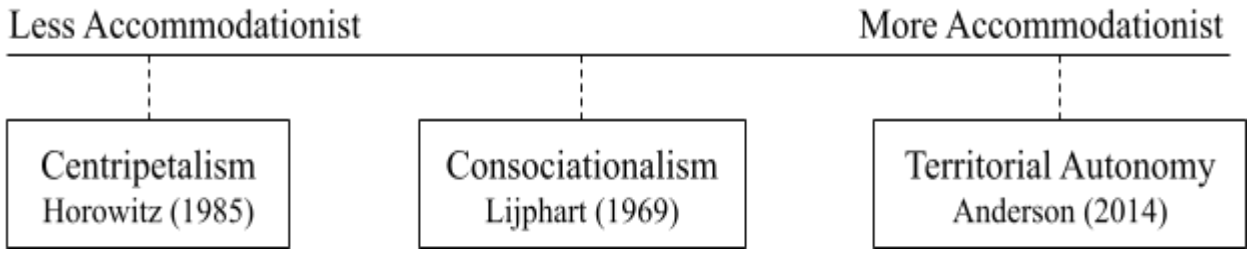
television (U.S. Department of State, 2026). The disproportionality is evident: Baloch, despite making up just 2% of the population, make up 25% of executed Iranians, while Kurds, around 10% of the population, account for over 50% of state killings due to “affiliation to banned opposition groups”. This cycle of escalating injustices to suppress grievances has made the Iranian state dependent on escalating violence, with 2025 recording the highest number of executions since 1989. Yet, the efficacy of these coercive tactics is waning (Iran Human Rights, 2024). The state's military response to the 2022 protests following the extrajudicial killing of Kurdish Mahsa Amini failed to crush demonstrations that continued through 2023 (Frantzman, 2023); the 2025-2026 protests saw the state struggle to maintain order despite massacring an estimated 6,425 to 36,500 Iranians and shutting down the nation's entire internet infrastructure (McClure & Parent, 2026). Alongside cultural persecution and economic marginalization, this trajectory demonstrates the institutional design’s inability to sustainably manage Iran’s diverse landscape.

IV. Theoretical Framework

To create an Iran that sustains peace and addresses past grievances, a new system of governance is required. While some view a transition to more moderate leadership within the existing government as a sufficient remedy, the Islamic Republic has demonstrated a structural inability to serve its multiethnic population and resolve critical horizontal inequalities necessary to avoid further conflict. Likewise, the exiled prince Reza Pahlavi’s proposal of a democratic Iran built on a majoritarian principle risks replicating ethnic exclusion through a Persian demographic majority (NUFDI Fund, 2026). The broader field of political science offers a range of prescriptive frameworks that have proven successful in managing deeply divided societies like Iran's. Power-sharing frameworks, the design of institutions that distribute political authority across diverse population groups, share a common foundation: stabilizing states challenged by deep ethnic, religious, or linguistic cleavages.

McGarry, O'Leary, and Simeon (2008) organize power-sharing frameworks along a spectrum from integration to accommodation. Integrationist strategies seek to construct a unified national identity by encouraging moderation and restricting attention to group differences, in some ways familiar to the Islamic Republic’s aggressive goal of consolidation. As the preceding analysis

demonstrates, ignoring ethnic differences and demands has only deepened rather than resolved cleavages. This study accordingly focuses on the accommodationist alternative: frameworks that treat the plurality of identities within a state as resilient and design institutions that support, rather than suppress, their expression (McGarry et al., 2008). Three such models, centripetalism, consociationalism, and ethno-federalism, offer distinct prescriptions for how power, ethnicity, and territory should interact, and are examined in order of their level of accommodation.



Centripetalism

Centripetalism emphasizes the ideas of "convergence, centrism, or bringing together" (Horowitz, 1985). Donald Horowitz argues that majoritarian electoral systems in ethnically divided societies produce ethnically aligned parties; thus, when one ethnic group holds a population majority, a centrifugal dynamic occurs: interethnic competition is disincentivized because cross-group campaigning is unnecessary for the majority to secure victory. To mitigate this, Horowitz's centripetal model redesigns electoral institutions to create incentives for politicians to appeal across ethnic boundaries, wherein systems appeal to rationality by "making moderation pay" (Horowitz, 1985). Preferential voting systems, such as the Alternative Vote (AV) and Single Transferable Vote (STV), encourage vote-pooling as candidates must capture support beyond their traditional base. By decreasing the political salience of ethnic divides through institutional incentives, centripetal integration presents cross-ethnic coalition-building as a long-term solution to sustain interethnic power-sharing and moderate platforms (Horowitz, 1985).

Consociationalism

Consociationalism aims to unite fragmented political elites through prescriptions primarily across legislative and executive institutions. Arend Lijphart posited consociational theory under the premise that democratic stability in divided societies depended on rival elites choosing cooperation over conflict. Like Horowitz, Lijphart recognized how majoritarian democracies risk

excluding minority groups, with larger groups able to dominate those smaller. With a focus on rival political elites, consociationalism addresses the dangers of fragmentation and interethnic division through four pillars: grand coalitions, proportionality, mutual veto rights, and segmented autonomy (Lijphart, 1969; 2004).

Grand Coalition	Executive power is shared among representatives from all major segments; the principle of inclusive governance
Proportionality	Within all political representation, civil service appointments, and public resource allocations (beyond proportional representation)
Mutual Veto	Each segment retains the power to block decisions that threaten vital interests
Segmental Autonomy	Each group retains a limited authority to govern certain affairs of its own (eg, culture, education)

Lijphart views consociationalism as foundational for providing "jointness…across the most significant communities". However, defining which groups are 'significant' to benefit from consociationalist prescriptions remains unclear; McGarry and O'Leary elaborated on this ambiguity by outlining two courses for classification: corporate, in which predetermined groups share power, and liberal, in which segments self-determine their representation. Liberal consociationalism, they argue, is more favorable to diverse ethnic populations because it avoids the rigid and discriminatory classification problems inherent in corporatism (McGarry & O'Leary, 2007).

Ethno-federalism

Ethno-federalism, or territorial autonomy, grants divided ethnic groups constitutionally protected powers of self-governance. The underlying logic is that minority groups with self-governing institutions can address regional inequalities that a central government has failed or refused to resolve. Ethno-federalism has arguably received the most skepticism regarding its efficacy to stabilize divided societies, with critics pointing to the historic collapses of the Soviet Union and Yugoslavia. Anderson defended ethno-federalism by distinguishing three types: full ethno-federations, in which all subunits are organized as ethnic homelands; partial ethno-federations, in which some but not all regions are drawn along ethnic lines; and ethnic federacies, in which one or more ethnic regions are granted autonomous status within an

otherwise unitary state. Through this delineation, Anderson then demonstrated how the success of an ethno-federation strongly correlates with its type (Anderson, 2014).

	Full Ethno-federations	Partial Ethno-federations	Ethnic Federacies
Examples	Soviet Union, Nigeria, Ethiopia, Yugoslavia, Pakistan, Malaysia,	Canada, India, Iraq, Russia, South Africa, Switzerland	Crimea/Ukraine, Scotland&Wales/UK, Greenland/Denmark
Success Rate	33 percent	100 percent	96 percent

The pattern of failure is concentrated almost entirely among full federations, all of which exhibit authoritarianism. Anderson argues that this has misled critics into dismissing ethno-federalism as a whole; McGarry and O'Leary reinforce this conclusion by attributing most failures to subsequent attempts to recentralize power, rather than to the design itself. The overwhelming success rates of partial ethno-federations and ethnic federacies suggest that selective, asymmetric autonomy is both viable and promising (McGarry and O'Leary, 2009).

V. Evaluative Criteria

To assess which mechanism is most viable for a post-transition Iran, this paper employs a four-pronged evaluative criterion. Each isolates a distinct dimension of Iran's institutional design problem, grounded in the theoretical literature and empirical conditions as established prior.

Criterion	Core Question	Iran-specific Application	Theoretical Foundations
Ethnic Complexity Fit	Can the mechanism accommodate multiple significant groups with cross-cutting identities?	Iran maintains six major ethnic groups-models serving only larger groups risk replicating exclusion; models must remain flexible to demographic shifts and cross-cutting cleavages	McGarry & O'Leary (2007); Lijphart (2004)
Territorial Integrity Compatibility	Can the mechanism manage secessionist risk where minorities border ethnic kin states?	Every major minority, except Lurs, occupies provinces on international frontiers; the design must minimize the risk of empowering secessionists	Anderson (2014); McGarry & O'Leary (2009)
Grievance Responsiveness	Can the mechanism address the specific historical and	Decades of cultural, economic, and political discrimination and repression require substantive institutional	Horowitz (1985); Cederman et al.

	contemporary grievances driving ethnic mobilization?	mechanisms capable of addressing deep grievances, not symbolic inclusion	(2013)
Comparative Record	What does evidence from analogous cases suggest about the model's performance?	While no single case replicates Iran's conditions, comparative evidence can illuminate implementation risks and institutional design lessons	Anderson (2014); McGarry & O'Leary (2007; 2009)

These criteria are not independent of one another: a mechanism that scores well on grievance responsiveness but poorly on territorial integrity compatibility may generate new risks even as it resolves old ones. The evaluation that follows, therefore, considers each mechanism's compatibility in its totality, not just isolated performance. To facilitate this comparison, each mechanism is scored on a three-point scale against each criterion.

Score	Meaning	Standard
0	Fails to meet	The mechanism lacks a credible response to this dimension of Iran's design problem; the application may reproduce or worsen existing conditions
1	Partially addresses	The mechanism engages this dimension, but with notable limitations, dependencies, or implementation risks that leave gaps unresolved
2	Satisfies	The mechanism provides a substantive response to this dimension, supported by comparative evidence or strong institutional logic

Following this analysis, scores are assigned to demonstrate the extent to which frameworks satisfy key dimensions of Iran's institutional design problem. The scoring framework is ordinal and serves to structure comparison of relative strengths and weaknesses, not to produce a definitive numerical evaluation.

	Ethnic Complexity Fit	Territorial Integrity	Grievance Responsiveness	Comparative Record	Total
Centripetalism	/2	/2	/2	/2	/8
Consociationalism	/2	/2	/2	/2	/8
Ethno-federalism	/2	/2	/2	/2	/8

VI. Centripetalism



The least accommodationist of the three mechanisms, centripetalism is the most conducive model to Iran's existing institutional infrastructure: a reengineered electoral system that incentivizes politicians to campaign across ethnic lines. In a country where Persians dominate the voting class, centripetalist elections would prompt candidates to build cross-ethnic governing coalitions and moderate their positions, thereby reducing the political salience of ethnicity and broadening representation for minorities interests. However, when assessed against the evaluative criteria, centripetalism's viability as a primary framework for Iran becomes difficult to sustain.

Ethnic Complexity Fit

It is unclear in practice how effective centripetalism would be in accommodating the interests of Iran's numerous ethnic groups. Though centripetal tools like alternative voting (AV) shift the electoral calculus, without a broader vote pool, Iran's unique demographic landscape complicates AV's potential efficacy; as Horowitz emphasizes, AV voting "would have an accommodative effect only if constituencies were heterogeneous" (Horowitz, 1991). Given that Iran's ethnic population is spread across provinces, often dominated by a single ethnic group, centripetalism may generate the least cross-ethnic incentives precisely where they are needed most. While centripetalism may be more impactful in national elections, it is likely insufficient on its own in regional and provincial elections. The single transferable vote (STV), which Horowitz acknowledged favors proportionality over moderation, faces a similar limitation: Iran's smallest minorities, such as Baloch, Arabs, and Turkmen, would still struggle to secure meaningful representation given their small electorates.

Territorial Integrity

With regard to territorial integrity, centripetalism is relatively strong in principle. As it deters ethnically defined political movements, centripetalism has a mitigative strength in reducing secessionist risks. However, this can also be a potential weakness: limiting its suite of accommodative concessions can frustrate ethnic groups whose only avenue for substantive change is a reworked electoral system. Lacking popular support or political salience, injustices, such as the state's extraction of oil from Khuzestan, can remain unresolved and contribute to secessionist sentiment.

Grievance Responsiveness

Centripetalism's greatest weakness comes with its grievance responsiveness. Its core focus on moderating elections neglects attending to the institutions that produce exclusion. Horowitz's assumption that "politicians are rational actors" and govern reflecting their broadened voter base overestimates what electoral moderation can achieve against decades of entrenched state discrimination (Horowitz, 1991). A more moderate Iranian political class might ban Gozinesh in policy, but enforcement would remain within the same institutional apparatus. Without a deeper institutional redesign, centripetal incentives alone cannot translate a mandate for change into a remedy.

Comparative Record

The evidence for evaluating the lone implementation of centripetalism is thin and mixed. Horowitz's case studies showed that centripetal mechanisms produced positive accommodative results only under narrow and often non-replicable conditions (Horowitz, 1991).

Case	Outcome	Relevance	Limitation
Lebanon (1943-1976)	Mixed electoral slates in heterogeneous constituencies sustained a cross-ethnic voting pool	Demonstrated that requiring candidates to pool votes could create moderation over time	Lacked true electoral incentives; candidates forced onto mixed slates, broke down once the requirement ended
Malaysia (1955-)	Interethnic coalition successfully pooled votes	Vote pooling can produce accommodative	Emerged from fortuitous, non-replicable conditions

	across ethnic lines, rewarding moderation	governance in a deeply divided society	
Nigeria (post-1979)	Presidential distribution requirement incentivized cross-ethnic outreach for the executive	Closest model for combining the majority threshold with geographic distribution in a multiethnic country	Legislature elected in homogenous constituencies (no interethnic compromise); a problem that Iran's segregated provinces would replicate
Sri Lanka (1978-)	AV for presidential elections broadened the minority support base	Shows AV's potential to incentivize cross-ethnic second-preference bargaining	Civil war and boycotts prevented competitive conditions for a normal second-preference test

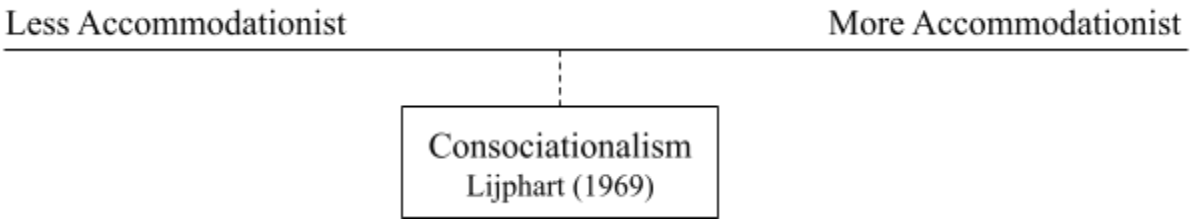
Centripetalism is not without value for Iran: its emphasis on cross-ethnic coalition-building addresses a risk that post-transition politics could fail to acknowledge and cause a renewed fracture along ethnic lines. But as a standalone framework, it lacks the institutional depth to address deep grievance. Alongside other power-sharing prescriptions, its electoral engineering may contribute to long-term cross-ethnic cooperation and moderation in Iranian politics.

Mechanism Evaluation

Criterion	Assessment	Score
Ethnic Complexity Fit	AV and vote-pooling require heterogeneous constituencies that Iran's segregated provincial geography struggles to provide; small minorities lack second-preference weight	1
Territorial Integrity	Avoids creating secessionist infrastructure, but offers no mechanism to address regional demands that drive separatist sentiment	2
Grievance Responsiveness	Addresses electoral polarization but not the structural causes of cultural, economic, and political exclusion embedded in centralized governance	0
Comparative Record	Too limited and dissimilar to be of comparative use with Iran's complex context: Malaysia (fortuitous); Nigeria (parallels one element); Sri Lanka (disrupted test); Lebanon (corporate classifications)	0
Total		3/8

Key: 0 (fails to meet); 1 (partially addresses); 2 (satisfies)

VII. Consociationalism



Consociationalism occupies the center of the accommodationist spectrum, prescribing structural power-sharing reforms across the executive, legislature, civil service, and judiciary. Whereas centripetalism relies on electoral incentives, Lijphart's model operates by unifying a "cartel of elites" to choose institutional cooperation over conflict (Lijphart, 1969). For a post-transition Iran, where decades of Persian monopolization have excluded minorities from meaningful governance, this emphasis on inclusive institutions is immediately relevant. Its viability, however, depends largely on implementation; whether prescriptions that promote elite cooperation are a sufficient remedy for a fragile post-transition Iran remains unclear.

Ethnic Complexity Fit

Consociationalism's capacity to accommodate Iran's ethnic complexity depends on the variant adopted. Corporate consociationalism is likely to be problematic: Iran's multi-ethnic landscape and wide variation in group sizes would make any fixed segmentation vulnerable to excluding smaller communities like the Baloch, Arabs, and Turkmen, while demographic shifts and census ambiguity would render ascribed categories inaccurate. Lijphart himself conceded that "electoral systems with guaranteed representation for particular minorities…[risk perpetuating] the same discriminatory choices" the system aims to resolve (Lijphart, 2004). Liberal consociationalism avoids this rigidity by accommodating to whatever political identities emerge democratically. Combined with grand coalitions mandating shared executive power, consociationalism offers a credible institutional framework that adequately includes Iranian communities historically excluded from decision-making authority.

Territorial Integrity

Consociationalism's relationship with territorial integrity hinges on how segmental autonomy is implemented. Lijphart distinguishes between non-territorial autonomy, in which groups govern cultural and local affairs regardless of location, and territorial autonomy, in which decentralized powers are granted to "geographically concentrated communal groups" (Lijphart, 2004). For Iran, this distinction is consequential: territorial autonomy risks furnishing ethnic groups in peripheral provinces with institutional resources for secession (though this dynamic is discussed in greater detail in the following ethno-federalism section). Non-territorial segmental autonomy, by contrast, allows for Iranian ethnic communities to reconstruct repressed cultural and political identities without proliferating a risk of secession. Paired with proportional representation in central governance, this consociational approach balances accommodation with territorial stability.

Grievance Responsiveness

Consociationalism's four pillars map directly onto Iran's ethnic grievances. Proportional representation would dismantle Gozinesh's discriminatory system and mandate "broad representation of all communal groups…in the civil service, judiciary, police, and military". Grand coalitions would empower excluded minorities with meaningful executive power. Mutual veto rights would provide institutional safeguards against the kind of majoritarian overreach that threatens to "affect the rights and autonomy of minorities," given a history of Persian-dominant governance (Lijphart, 2004). Segmental autonomy in education can catalyze reforms that meet the specific needs of ethnic minorities, who have argued that rigidity demonstrably harms student performance across their communities. Taken together, consociationalism's foundational characteristics illustrate a high degree of suitability in addressing Iran's most salient grievances.

Comparative Record

The comparative evidence for consociationalism is richer than for centripetalism, with an observable correlation with the mechanism's success and the specific design choices made within it. Iraq, in particular, is useful for evaluating consociationalism in a post-transition Iran, given a similar multiethnic landscape shaped by decades of repression under a centralized government dominated by a single group.

Case	Outcome	Relevance to Iran	Limitation
Lebanon (1943-)	Corporate consociation led to conflict when fixed representative segments became unrepresentative	Lack of census data and changing demographics can cause the use of fixed segments in Iran to fail	Segments based on an inaccurate 1932 census; efficacy is unclear if reflected the population
Cyprus (1960-1963)	Corporate consociation with fixed Greek-Turkish ratios; collapsed within three years	The dominant group, resented by minorities, was vetoed consistently, leading to legislative deadlock	Only a three-year lifespan; arguably, a deeper ethnic conflict/distrust than in Iran; foreign interference
Bosnia-Herzegovina (1995–)	Corporate consociation imposed by external forces with a fixed three-way power division; functional but deeply dysfunctional	Demonstrates how externally imposed corporate arrangements can entrench ethnic divisions rather than resolve them	Design imposed under international military supervision, lacking an internal consociational mandate
Belgium (1970-)	Constitutionally mandated cabinet representation; long-standing functional consociational governance	Demonstrates that consociationalism can maintain long-term institutional ethnic trust	Ethnic divide between the two groups, unlike Iran's 6+ identities; extreme gridlocks in governance
South Africa (1994-96)	Liberal consociation via party-based power sharing; peaceful post-authoritarian government transition	Demonstration that liberal consociationalism can mitigate violence from oppressed ethnic groups	Interim arrangement only lasting two years; elites shifted to a majoritarian democracy
Northern Ireland (1998-)	A hybrid liberal design with corporate features; sustained power sharing across a deep sectarian divide	Consociationalism can endure across deep divisions when, like Iran, external conditions favor cooperation (eg, USA)	Bipolar division to Iran's multipolar landscape; the UK's connection to Ireland is far deeper than Western interests in Iran; gridlock
Iraq (2005-)	Liberal design; devolved into ethno-sectarian quota sharing, leading to corruption, gridlock, and ethnic distrust	Closest demographic and regional parallel to Iran; post-conflict stability and resilience to crises suggest theoretical viability for Iran	Liberal design failed to safeguard against elite corruption; questionable whether Iraq is a successful democracy

These cases validate a theorized pattern: corporate arrangements produce rigidity and dysfunction, while liberal designs demonstrate greater resilience. Yet the applicability of even the successful cases is limited. Belgium and Northern Ireland's case, consociationalism's most durable examples, have notable limitations: both are bipolar divisions and suffer from recurring governance paralysis (Belgium recently went over 600 days without a permanent government). A post-transition Iran, navigating a multipolar ethnic landscape with far less institutional stability,

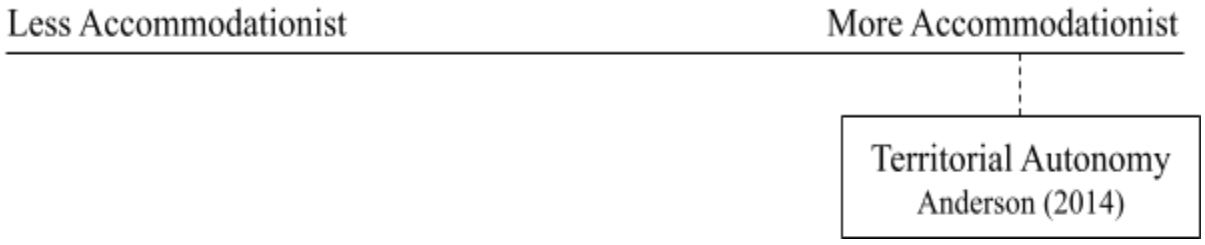
would be unlikely to absorb the costs of deadlock with similar success, limiting these cases' comparative utility.

Mechanism Evaluation

Criterion	Assessment	Score
Ethnic Complexity Fit	Largely dependent on a variant of consociationalism: liberal accommodates Iran's cross-cutting identities, while corporatism would fix segments and risk excluding minorities; liberal model can drift to corporate practice (Iraq)	1
Territorial Integrity	Non-territorial autonomy minimally risks developing secessionist infrastructure, while addressing regional cultural grievances, though territorial autonomy carries high risks of weakening territorial stability	1
Grievance Responsiveness	Four pillars create a dedicated framework that addresses political exclusion, economic discrimination, minority protections, and cultural self-determination; gaps remain, but architecture capable of response	2
Comparative Record	Cases show a pattern of corporate designs failing while liberal designs demonstrate greater resilience; Iraq, as the closest parallel, shows both promise and corporate drift; successful cases are limited in comparability	1
Total		5/8

Key: 0 (fails to meet); 1 (partially addresses); 2 (satisfies)

VIII. Ethno-Federalism



Sitting at the end of the accommodationist spectrum, ethno-federalism seeks to mitigate deep ethnic grievances by creating "subunit boundaries…[that] conform to the territorial distribution of ethnic groups". Of the three mechanisms, its prescriptions most directly align with what most of Iran's ethnic population have consistently demanded: protected rights to self-governance.

However, as Anderson argued, ethno-federal designs vary significantly in their assumptions and risks (Anderson, 2014). An ethnic-federacy would make minority self-governance dependent on central goodwill that ethnic groups fundamentally distrust, while a full ethno-federation would impose unnecessary ethnic categorization on Iran's 17 majority-Persian provinces. Partial ethno-federalism, in which ethnically defined provinces coexist with non-ethnic federal units within a single constitutional framework, emerges as the most suitable subtype for Iran's conditions and serves as the basis for the following evaluation.

Ethnic Complexity Fit

A partial ethno-federation accommodates Iran's ethnic complexity through asymmetry; it calibrates the character and degree of autonomy to each province's specific demands and viability. Iran's existing provincial structure already provides a helpful foundation for this: provinces like Sistan-Baluchestan and Khuzestan, where Baloch and Arab demands for autonomy are strongest, can receive expanded governing rights without redrawing internal boundaries (Farouk & Jalal, 2026). Azeris and Lurs, whose deeper integration into Persian culture has been less supportive of similar autonomous-governing demands, may not desire a similar redesign. Meanwhile, the majority-Persian provinces would avoid the needless restructure that a full ethno-federation would demand. A key limitation remains for groups too small or dispersed to warrant their own federal unit. Turkmen illustrate this, lacking a clear majority in Golestan province and likely remaining under a Persian-majority administration. Despite this, partial ethno-federalism's asymmetric design offers a versatile framework to accommodate most of Iran's diverse ethnic landscape.

Territorial Integrity

Territorial integrity is where federalism faces its greatest challenge. Critics like Roeder argue that ethno-federalism "furnishes ethnic leaders with the institutional resources necessary to mount a secessionist challenge" (Anderson, 2014). For Iran, this risk is concrete: the Kurdistan Free Life Party (PJAK) has waged armed conflict since 2004 seeking to create an 'Eastern Kurdistan', while the People's Fighters Front (PFF) recently unified Baloch militant groups into a nationalist front (Vaziri, 2026). Two counterarguments temper this concern. First, Anderson's findings show that an overwhelming majority of failed ethno-federacies have been 'full'; partial designs, with

asymmetries, allow flexibility in granting autonomy to provinces at varying levels of risk (Anderson, 2014) . Second, McGarry and O'Leary observe that states "built around a historically dominant nationality…[tend] more democratically stable"; Iran's large Persian majority and widely shared cultural identity lower the baseline risk for fragmentation (McGarry and O'Leary, 2009). Nevertheless, the risk must not be understated given Iran's extremely weak condition. Even the most promising mitigations can plausibly fail to prevent those committed to separating from hijacking these reforms to their cause. Partial ethno-federalism remains viable, but its implementation would require constitutional safeguards and province-by-province calibration to minimize the risk of inadvertently contributing to secession.

Grievance Responsiveness

Ethno-federalism is the only mechanism that directly addresses the territorial and self-determinant dimensions of Iran's grievances. Regional self-governance would enable Kurdish provinces to administer education in their own languages, grant Arabs authority over oil extraction and reinvestment in Khuzestan, and allow Sistan-Baluchestan's government to be composed by its Baloch population (Mahdi, 2024). Anderson's findings that 27 of 43 were ethno-federations implemented to "resolve a problem that unitary institutions created or could not resolve, and they have [all], to date, succeeded", reinforce the mechanism's grievance-response potential (Anderson, 2014). Yet this record must be qualified: in nearly every successful case, ethno-federal designs operated alongside complementary institutional tools. By itself, it cannot address national-level horizontal inequalities like Gozinesh discrimination, proportional representation, and protections against majoritarian overreach. Ethno-federalism addresses grievances at the regional level, but cannot, alone, reform the center.

Comparative Record

Anderson's dataset provides a systematic empirical base for comparative analysis. Given that the preceding analysis has identified a partial ethno-federation as the most conducive subtype for Iran, the comparative focus is narrowed accordingly (Anderson, 2014). Once again, Iraq serves as an extremely valuable case study for diagnosing the mechanism's applicability in Iran.

Case	Outcome	Relevance to Iran	Limitation

Switzerland (1848-)	Multilingual federation combining territorial, linguistic, and religious accommodation	Most successful concurrent ethno-federation to date; combined consociational governance at the center	Historically isolated from conflict and no authoritarian history; very dissimilar to Iran
Canada (1867-)	Asymmetric federation accommodating French Quebec within an English-majority state	Minority French demands autonomy within; calls for separation have been mostly subdued democratically	Ethnic majority far less than Persians; Asian groups are near 30% without accommodation
India (1956-)	Linguistic reorganization of states; the world's largest enduring multiethnic democracy	Demonstrates federalism's ability to manage extreme diversity at scale with a dominant majority group	Hindu majority (80%) far exceeds Iran's 61%; inter-ethnic conflict is common in India
Nigeria (1967-)	Post-Civil War federation created to prevent any single group from dominating a homeland unit	Federal redesign after failed unitarism and civil war, successfully stabilized a deeply divided state	Ethnic violence has persisted; long period of military rule and suppression of freedoms
Spain (1978-)	Post-authoritarian transition granted asymmetric autonomy to Catalonia, Basque Country, and Galicia	Reflective case: centralized authoritarian predecessor, asymmetric design, and multiple ethnic regions	Catalan crisis (2017) shows how asymmetric autonomy can empower secessionists
Iraq (2005-)	Kurdistan Regional Government granted extensive autonomy within Arab-majority federation	Closest regional parallel: multiethnic Middle Eastern state, post-authoritarian, US intervention	2017 Kurdish independence bid saw 93% of Kurds vote in favor of secession

The comparative evidence from partial ethno-federalism is cautiously favorable: every case has negated secessionist fears and maintained institutional stability. Anderson's evaluation of a 'success' is notably a low bar, as several cases are better described as fragile than stable ethno-federacies. Though no one state perfectly parallels Iran's context, the cases demonstrate that partial ethno-federations can survive secessionist movements, stabilize deeply divided states after civil war, facilitate peaceful post-authoritarian transitions, and function in a multiethnic Middle Eastern context.

Mechanism Evaluation

Criterion	Assessment	Score
Ethnic	Partial ethno-federation accommodates Iran's territorial ethnic concentration	2

Complexity Fit	through asymmetric design; it avoids drawing new borders and unnecessary categorization. Even as not every minority group can be served (eg. Turkmen), asymmetry sufficiently addresses critical complexities	
Territorial Integrity	Secessionist risk is real: armed peripheral groups (PJAK & PFF) continue to grow in salience and may not be satisfied with limited territorial concessions; risky, though empirically proven to be manageable in analogous cases	1
Grievance Responsiveness	Only mechanism directly addressing territorial and regional grievances; a valuable tool to promote regional justice, but insufficient for dealing with national-level grievances without complementary mechanisms	1
Comparative Record	Every partial ethno-federation in Anderson's dataset has survived where unitarian governance failed to address deep grievances; while no case individually replicates Iran's features, individual elements are parallel, and successes across diverse cases add to the model's external validity	2
Total		6/8

Key: 0 (fails to meet); 1 (partially addresses); 2 (satisfies)

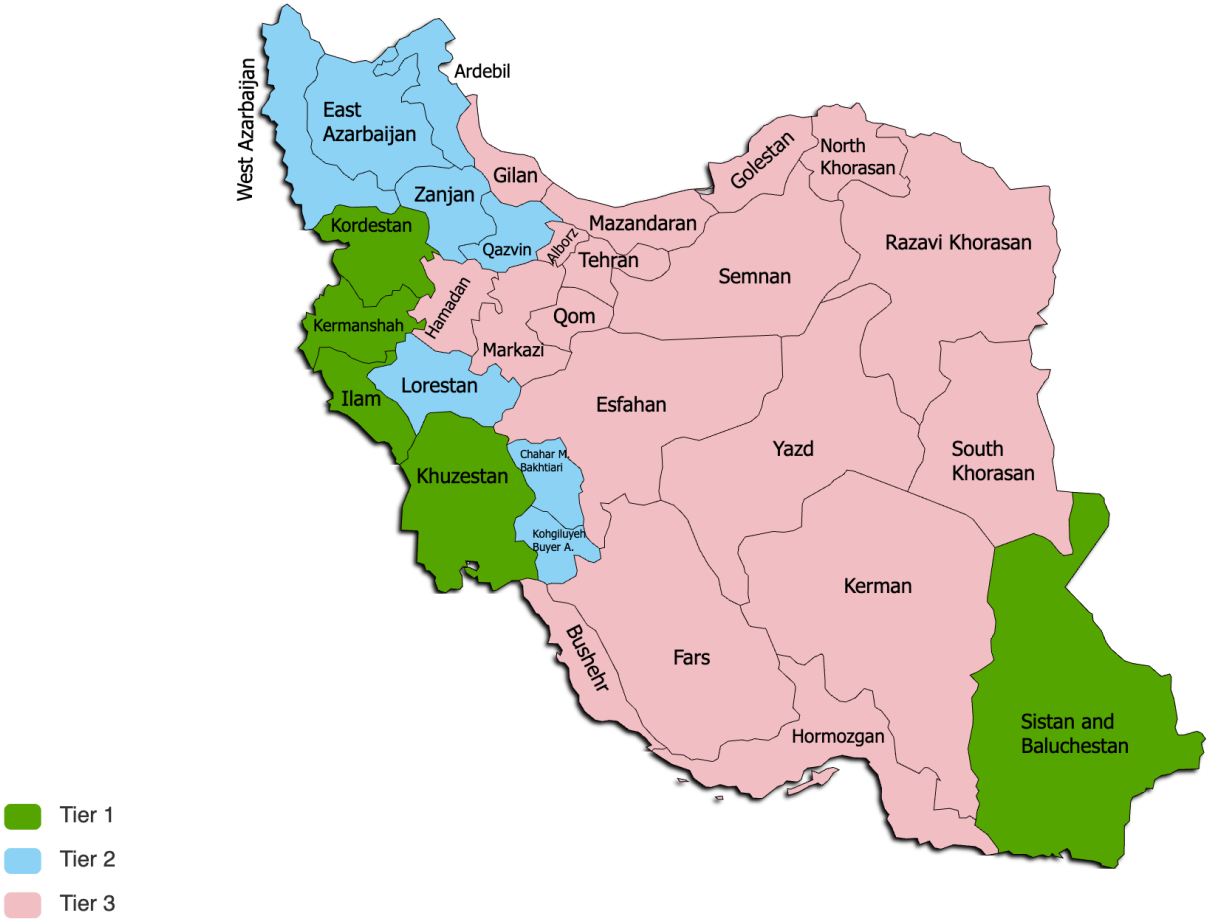
IX. Synthesis: A Hybrid Framework

No single power-sharing mechanism can independently manage the complexity of a post-transition Iran. Centripetalism (3/8) lacks the institutional depth to address grievances beyond electoral reform; Consociationalism (5/8) offers a comprehensive framework for inclusive governance, but is limited by territorial demands and risks of institutional paralysis; Ethno-federalism (6/8) directly addresses regional and self-determinant grievances driving ethnic mobilization, but cannot alone reform the national institutions that produced them. The most viable framework, therefore, is not a choice between these models but a synthesis: a constitutionally anchored partial ethno-federation supported by consociational principles at the center, with centripetal incentives to sustain long-term cross-ethnic moderation.

The foundation of this framework is a constitutionally entrenched partial ethno-federation built on Iran's existing 31-province structure to avoid wholesale territorial redesign. Rather than imposing uniform autonomy, the design calibrates governing powers asymmetrically, with at least three tiers of autonomy. The first grants the greatest autonomy to provinces where grievance

severity and demands for self-governance are strongest: Kurdistan, Sistan-Baluchestan, and Khuzestan, adding regional influence for education policy, economic development, and administrative decisions. The next tier provides a more limited degree of cultural and bureaucratic autonomy for less-mobilized and better-integrated ethnic populations, such as the Azerbaijani-majority northwest provinces and Lur-concentrated regions. Finally, the remaining Persian-majority provinces would retain their administrative character without requiring an institutional redesign. These provincial rights must be constitutionally anchored to cultivate ethnic minority trust in the long-term sustainment of their rights under future governments. Because Iran has not conducted an ethnic census since 1976, any federal redesign would require contemporaneous demographic data collection as a prerequisite; the map below, therefore, serves as an illustrative projection rather than a definitive boundary proposal

Post-Transition Iranian Partial Ethno-federation by Province



Tier	Provinces	Count (of 31)	Devolved Powers
1	Kordestan, Sistan-Baluchestan, Khuzestan, Ilam, Kermanshah	5	Education, language, & resource/ revenue-investment
2	East/West Azerbaijan, Zanjan, Lorestan, Qazvin, Chahar, Ardebil, Mahall & Bakhtiari, Kohgiluyeh & Boyer-Ahmad	9	Cultural & limited administrative autonomy
3	Tehran, Esfahan, Fars, Yazd, Golestan, Gilan, Bushehr, Alborz, Hormozgan, South//North/Razavi Khorasan, Mazandaran, Hamadan, Markazi, Qom, Semnan	17	Standard federal administration

Consociationalism, particularly through liberal consociational principles, offers an invaluable mechanism for resolving past horizontal inequalities and mitigating future grievances. Its broad foundational prescriptions, proportional representation, grand coalitions, mutual vetoes, and segmental autonomy address a suite of the most salient ethnic grievances held against the central state. Moreover, its power-sharing design creates the necessary frameworks to mitigate interethnic conflict through cooperative governance and shared stakes in critical decision-making processes for Iran.

Liberal consociational principles anchor national governance, ensuring that provincial autonomy is accompanied by inclusive central institutions. Each of Lijphart's four pillars operationalizes a remedy for Iran's grievance structure. A grand coalition executive would mandate that cabinet formation reflect the ethnic composition of the legislature rather than fixed quotas. To ensure the legislature is itself reflective, elections would operate under a proportional representation system using a highest-averages method such as D'Hondt. Unlike majoritarian systems, in which a Persian demographic majority could dominate every contested seat, proportional representation ensures that Baloch, Turkmen, and Arab parties that secure meaningful vote shares receive representation in the legislature and executive. Mutual veto rights require careful implementation. To avoid the governmental paralysis seen in Belgium and Bosnia, their scope should be restricted to minority cultural, linguistic, and religious affairs. Finally, non-territorial segmented autonomy addresses a gap that ethno-federalism cannot fill: communities too small or dispersed to form their own federal unit. Groups such as Turkmen, Armenians, and Baha'is can gain protection for their cultural institutions and education, regardless of demographic status.

Dimension	Current Design (Islamic Republic)	Proposed Consociational Reform
Executive Composition	Persian-Shia monopoly; certain minorities excluded from cabinet authority	Grand coalition cabinet derived from proportional legislative results
Legislative Representation	Majoritarian system enables Persian demographic dominance	D'Hondt proportional representation ensures minority legislative presence
Minority Protections	No institutional safeguard against majoritarian overreach	Mutual veto on cultural, linguistic, and religious legislation
Cultural Rights	Teaching and expressing minority culture can be considered a crime	Non-territorial segmental autonomy with constitutional protection

Centripetal electoral incentives prevent the framework's accommodationist architecture from cementing ethnic cleavages into permanent political divides; by promoting moderation within, the salience of ethnic divides decreases. Iranian executive elections that adopt an alternative voting system with a geographic distribution requirement would compel candidates to secure support across multiple provinces rather than relying solely on their ethnic base. This would cultivate a cross-ethnic political consciousness that engages Iranians as voters mobilized around platforms rather than cultural allegiance alone.

Advantages

Addresses grievances at both regional (ethno-federalism) and national (consociationalism) levels
Asymmetric federalism accommodates varying demands without imposing uniform reform
Constitutional entrenchment protects minority rights from reversal by future governments
Electoral-to-executive pipeline anchors legislative and cabinet inclusion to vote share
Proportional representation mandates ethnic inclusion across governance
Segmented autonomy extends protections to communities regardless of size or salience
Mutual veto rights, narrowly scoped, protect minorities against majoritarian overreach
Elections incentivize cross-ethnic cooperation and cultivate cross-ethnic political consciousness
Builds on Iran's existing 31-province structure without wholesale territorial redesign

These promises, however, must be qualified. The framework's viability depends on conditions that a post-transition Iran may struggle to provide, and several of the prescribed mechanisms carry inherent tensions that could produce new instabilities in the service of mitigating existing ones.

Risks

Tier I autonomous provinces may furnish secessionists (PJAK/PFF) with institutional resources
Miscalibration of provincial autonomy levels could generate new grievances
Absence of reliable ethnic census data means any demographic-dependent mechanism risks contestation
Requires a transitional process with authority and legitimacy to bind future governments to constitution
Path-dependent discrimination may persist within reformed institutions despite formal restructuring
Narrowly scoped mutual vetos do not eliminate the risk of government paralysis, especially if abused

The alternatives, maintaining a coercive centralized state or a standalone majoritarian democracy, carry far greater risks in their failure to resolve the core ethnic grievances threatening national stability. This hybrid framework offers the most credible institutional path toward an Iran that can sustainably balance its diversity and its territorial integrity.

X. Conclusion

Iran's longstanding reliance on coercive homogenization to maintain territorial integrity is structurally unsustainable. Centuries of horizontal inequalities have compounded into deep ethnic grievances that the current institutional design cannot resolve, but only suppress, with diminishing efficacy. This paper advances accommodationist power-sharing mechanisms as the most credible alternative. Evaluating centripetalism, consociationalism, and ethno-federalism against Iran's ethnic complexity, territorial vulnerabilities, grievance landscape, and comparative evidence, the analysis suggests no single mechanism is sufficient. The proposed hybrid, a constitutionally entrenched partial ethno-federalism, reinforced by liberal consociational principles and centripetal electoral incentives, synthesizes the strengths of each while mitigating their individual limitations. This framework carries real risks and offers no guarantee of success.

But the instability plaguing Iran predates the current crisis by generations; this framework aims to build an Iran that sustains its territorial integrity not by suppressing its diversity, but by empowering it.

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